The meeting started with Ratan welcoming the invitees. He then told them that he had several concerns about the functioning of Tata Sons. Thereafter, Soonawala made a presentation explaining how the performance of the group had dipped under Mistry. Singh also spoke about the lacklustre performance of the group under Mistry and how it had lost direction.

Ratan spoke next. He asked the trustees, ‘Do I have your permission to take necessary corrective steps in Tata Sons?’ He did not elaborate what those steps would be. All the trustees gave their approval. With this, the meeting ended at 1.15 p.m.

Just before 2 p.m., Ratan reached Bombay House. Nohria sought an appointment with Mistry for Ratan and himself. Ratan says Nohria was chosen as he was a ‘nominee director’ and ‘secondly [as] he was the most independent of the nominee directors. As dean of the business school, he did not have any axe to grind for anybody else.’ Nohria spoke to Mistry’s office and was promptly given the appointment. Ratan and he then walked to Mistry’s office on the fourth floor.

Mistry was occupying the room that Palkhivala and then Irani had occupied when they were directors in Tata Sons. It was not the room that the group chairman usually occupied. Ratan’s room had been given by Mistry to his closest confidante, Madhu Kannan, the former CEO of the Bombay Stock Exchange, who changed the entire character of the room. ‘That was a sad thing. This is something very wrong that Cyrus did. They tried to break the legacy of JRD. Even Ratan had not occupied the room that was Jeh’s out of respect until the last. Until then, he occupied a nearby small room. They had made small rooms and decimated it,’ said Irani. The room has since been restored by Chandrasekaran. He expended considerable effort and time in getting the architect to look for the original drawings.

Nohria knocked on the door of Mistry’s room and they entered to see an anxious-looking chairman rising from his chair. Nohria and Ratan walked towards Mistry’s desk and did not bother to be seated. Nor did Mistry offer them a seat. Nohria says, ‘He may not have known why we were coming’ but he was ‘not expecting a happy conversation’.

Nohria advised Mistry to resign from the post of chairman, Tata Sons. He remembers he said, ‘If you don’t do this, you should know that in the board meeting, we are going to introduce a motion to vote for your ouster. … I think it would be in everybody’s interest if you chose to resign.’